Chapters 3–5 Exam Prep: Instructor Key

PSY 385 Positive Psychology · Nov 2, 2026 · @LashaKho

How to use this key

This key gives the expected content for every item on the student checklist *Chapters 3–5 Exam Prep*. Use it to check a student's self-rating: a student who rates themselves 4 or 5 should be able to say most of the points in the middle column without notes.

- **Key points** = what a level-4 answer contains (definition plus a study or example).
- **Common errors** = the mistakes that show a student is really at level 2 or 3.
- **Level 5** = the student can also apply the idea to a case (such as Tariq or Dana) and compare it with the related concept named in the error column.

All content is summarised from Hefferon and Boniwell (2011), *Positive Psychology: Theory, Research and Applications*, Chapters 3–5.

Chapter 3: Happiness and Subjective Wellbeing across Nations

The chapter's core idea: SWB is the hedonic view of happiness, and most of what people expect to make them happy (money, possessions, choice) has a smaller and shorter effect than they predict.

Construct	Key points	Common errors
Subjective wellbeing (SWB)	SWB = life satisfaction + high positive affect + low negative affect (Diener). Life satisfaction is the cognitive judgement; affect is the emotional part. High SWB links to creativity, persistence, sociability, health and longevity.	Treating SWB as only "feeling good"; forgetting the cognitive part.

Construct	Key points	Common errors
Measuring SWB	Mostly short self-report scales: SWLS, Subjective Happiness Scale, PANAS. Good reliability and validity; agree with peer reports and ESM. Limits: mood at the moment, memory bias, impression management. Remedies: ESM, diaries, physiological measures, longitudinal designs.	Saying self-report is useless, or ignoring its biases.
Global surveys and the ladder of life	Gallup World Poll (150+ countries, ~98% of the world's adults), World Database of Happiness, World Values Survey. Cantril ladder 0–10, now and in 5 years: thriving (7+ now, 8+ future), struggling (5–6), suffering (4 or below).	Mixing up the ladder categories; thinking most people are unhappy (most score as somewhat satisfied).
Five ways to wellbeing; five elements	Foresight Report (NEF, 400+ studies): connect, be active, take notice, keep learning, give. Gallup (Rath & Harter): career, social, financial, physical, community wellbeing. Only about 7% do well in all five.	Mixing the two lists; forgetting that the elements work together.
The 40% solution and set point	About 50% genetic, 10% life circumstances, 40% intentional activity (Lyubomirsky). Dynamic equilibrium: personality sets a baseline we return to after events (Headey & Wearing). Set point theory is now debated.	Reading 40% as "you control 40% of any one person's happiness"; ignoring the critique of set point.

Construct	Key points	Common errors
Income and SWB	Richer countries score higher; money matters most where basic needs are not met. Forbes rich list only slightly happier than average. Diminishing returns after a moderate income. Costs: less leisure, the hedonic treadmill, materialism.	"Money does not buy happiness at all" or "more money always helps."
Relationships, marriage, children	Social time is one of the strongest predictors; people are happiest with others (Kahneman's ESM). Happiness spreads through networks (Fowler & Christakis). Marriage boost fades after about a year. Children: wellbeing drops, then recovers after they leave home (curvilinear).	Assuming children always raise happiness.
Work orientations	Job = means to an end (money); career = progress and extrinsic rewards; calling = work valued for itself. About one third see work as a calling, in any type of job.	Thinking a calling needs a "noble" job.
Health, religion, age, gender, education	Positive emotions predict resistance to colds (Cohen) and longer life (Pressman's psychologists). Too much optimism can delay medical help. Religion: small benefit, depends on type and culture. No real age or gender difference; education is linked to higher SWB.	Overstating the religion effect; assuming older people are less happy.

Construct	Key points	Common errors
Hedonic adaptation	We react strongly to events, then return to a set point (the hedonic treadmill). Lottery winners were no happier than before (Brickman). Antidote: variety and surprise (HAP model). Lasting exceptions: death of a spouse, long-term unemployment.	Saying adaptation is complete for every event.
Affective forecasting	People mispredict how strong and long their feelings will be (impact bias). Tenure study: both groups overestimated their reactions (Gilbert). Synthetic happiness, made when we do not get what we want, is as real as natural happiness.	Confusing impact bias with adaptation; calling synthetic happiness "fake."
Discrepancy theories	SWB depends on comparison with others, the past self and internal standards. American paradox: wealth rose, happiness did not (Myers). Valuing money predicts lower life satisfaction; valuing love predicts higher. "Affluenza." Materialism hurts less if you can afford it.	Treating all social comparison as harmful (downward and upward can both be used positively).
Paradox of choice	Too much choice causes information, error and psychological problems (Schwartz). Jam study: 24 jams drew more shoppers but 3% bought vs 30% with 6 jams (Iyengar & Lepper). Maximizers earn a bit more but are less happy than satisficers (regret, self-blame).	Saying any choice is bad; mixing up maximizer and satisficer.

Construct	Key points	Common errors
Bottom-up, top-down, goal theories	Bottom-up: specific factors (genes, demographics) cause SWB. Top-down: SWB shapes outcomes and how we see events. Goal theories: progress toward valued, self-congruent goals produces happiness.	Reversing bottom-up and top-down.
AIM and the peak-end rule	Attention (see the whole picture), Interpretation (avoid awfulizing, distress intolerance, learned helplessness, perfectionism, negative self-fulfilling expectancies, rejection goggles), Memory (savour good events). Peak-end rule: we judge experiences by their peak and end; duration neglect (colonoscopy study).	Listing AIM without the destructive thinking patterns.

Chapter 4: Eudaimonic Wellbeing

The chapter's core idea: feeling good is not enough for a good life. Wellbeing also depends on meaning, growth, engagement and living in line with one's values.

Construct	Key points	Common errors
Eudaimonia	Realising one's true nature or potential (daimon); roots in Aristotle. Happens when activities fit deep values (Waterman): developing the true self, doing things for their own sake, serving something larger.	Defining it as "a deeper kind of pleasure."

Construct	Key points	Common errors
Hedonic vs eudaimonic	SWB was criticised as hedonism that ignores growth and meaning (Ryan & Deci; Ryff). SWB and PWB are correlated but distinct factors (Keyes et al., 2002, 3,000+ people). Open questions: are they separate, overlapping or identical? Is eudaimonia a state, a process or a trait?	Saying the two are opposites, or that the field agrees on one definition.
Ryff's PWB	Six dimensions: self-acceptance, personal growth, purpose in life, positive relations, environmental mastery, autonomy. Only self-acceptance and mastery correlate well with SWB. Critique: may reduce to two factors (Vittersø).	Missing dimensions; confusing mastery with competence in SDT.
Authentic happiness	Three routes (Seligman): pleasant life (positive emotion), engaged life (absorption, flow), meaningful life (using strengths to serve something larger). The last two are eudaimonic. Pleasure lifts mood short-term; meaning gives long-term value.	Treating the routes as stages, or calling the pleasant life eudaimonic.
Flow: definition and conditions	Intense absorption in a moment-to-moment activity at full capacity (Csikszentmihalyi). Conditions: clear goals and feedback, challenge matched to skill, merging of action and awareness, sense of control, altered sense of time, activity done for its own sake.	Equating flow with relaxation or fun.

Construct	Key points	Common errors
Challenge–skill model	High challenge + low skill = anxiety; low challenge + high skill = boredom; low both = apathy (e.g. TV); high both = flow channel.	Placing TV in boredom instead of apathy.
Who, where, benefits and dangers	10–15% never report flow; 10–15% daily. Measured with ESM (beeper). Common in sport, arts, study and, surprisingly, work; rare in TV and housework (culture matters). Autotelic personality: curious, persistent, intrinsically motivated. Benefits: performance, engagement, learning. Dangers: flow in harmful activities (gambling) and addiction.	Saying flow is always morally good.
Meaning and purpose	Meaning is essential to wellbeing; meaninglessness is linked to existential fear and poor outcomes (Steger; Wong). Purpose helps protect against suicidal behaviour. Meaning systems differ in differentiation, elaboration and coherence. MLQ: presence vs search.	Treating presence and search as the same thing.
Frankl and sources of meaning	Will to meaning is the primary human drive. Three values: creative, experiential, attitudinal. Seven cross-cultural sources: achievement, acceptance, relationship, intimacy, religion, self-transcendence, fairness.	Listing Frankl's values as "pleasure, power, meaning."

Construct	Key points	Common errors
Self-determination theory	Three basic needs: autonomy (acting from one's own volition), competence (mastery, effect on the environment), relatedness (connection and care). Some add physical thriving and security.	Defining autonomy as independence from others.
Existential positive psychology	Combines existential and positive psychology (Wong). Three mature happinesses: authentic, eudaimonic, chaironic (a gift, independent of circumstances). Happiness is a process; contentment can leave a void; discontent can drive growth; consumerism harms the search for the self.	Saying existential psychology is only about the dark side.
Death, meaning management, terror management	Three death attitudes: neutral acceptance, approach acceptance, escape acceptance. Meaning management theory: facing death can make life more authentic. Terror management: mortality salience makes people defend their worldview and conform.	Mixing up approach acceptance and escape acceptance.
Integrating hedonic and eudaimonic	Eudaimonic pursuits relate to life satisfaction, growth and challenge; hedonic ones to positive affect and relaxation. The field lacks one definition; more qualitative and bottom-up research is needed.	Claiming one approach has "won."

Chapter 5: Optimism, Explanatory Style and Hope

The chapter's core idea: how people expect the future to go, and how they explain what has happened, shapes coping, health and achievement. But optimism is not always good, and pessimism is not always bad.

Construct	Key points	Common errors
History of optimism	Once seen as naive denial; mental health was defined as accurate "reality testing" (1930s–60s). Now seen as a resource linked to happiness, health and achievement — a "Velcro construct" (Peterson). About 25–30% of variation is genetic.	Saying psychology always valued optimism.
Dispositional optimism	A personality trait: a general expectancy that outcomes will be good (Scheier & Carver). Part of a self-regulation model: optimists keep going toward goals; pessimists give up. Two elements: expectancy (most important) and confidence. Measured with the LOT-R (items 2, 5, 6, 8 are fillers; no cut-off).	Calling it learned; scoring the filler items.
Explanatory style	How people explain the causes of past events (Seligman). Pessimists explain bad events as internal, stable and global; optimists as external, unstable and specific. Stability and globality matter more than internality. Bad-event explanations matter more than good-event ones. Measured with the ASQ (vignettes). Grew from learned helplessness.	Thinking internal attributions are always pessimistic; ignoring that stability and globality matter most.

Construct	Key points	Common errors
Trait vs learned optimism	Dispositional optimism = stable trait about what will happen. Explanatory style = learned skill about why things happened, so it can be changed (similar to CBT). The two measures still correlate.	Treating them as the same theory.
Learned optimism and ABC	Adversity (the facts), Belief (the automatic explanation), Consequence (feelings and actions). Identify beliefs, then dispute them and reframe. Studies: optimistic speech in US presidential elections; optimistic insurance agents sold 88% more.	Skipping the Belief step or the disputing step.
Benefits of optimism	Optimists feel less distress and use active coping (planning, seeking support, reframing, humour); pessimists use avoidant coping (denial, distraction). Predicts lower depression in students and new mothers. Health: faster recovery after bypass surgery (Scheier et al.), better health habits.	Saying optimists ignore threats (they attend to health warnings).
Positive illusions	Most people see themselves, their control and their future in an unrealistically positive light (Taylor). These illusions may help people cope and find meaning in severe illness.	Assuming accuracy is always healthier.

Construct	Key points	Common errors
Locus of control and perceived control	Internal LOC: success depends on one's own effort; external: luck, chance or powerful others (Rotter). Not fixed; varies by situation. Internals work harder, plan long-term and get somewhat better grades, but feel more guilt. Nursing home plants study: residents given choice and responsibility were more active and had lower mortality 15 months later (Langer & Rodin). Thompson's three ways to keep control.	Calling internal LOC always positive and external always negative (Rotter warned against this).
Defensive pessimism	Setting low expectations despite past success, then planning for everything that could go wrong (Norem & Cantor). Harnesses anxiety; leads to good performance, rising self-esteem and goal progress. Making defensive pessimists think positively hurts their performance.	Treating it as the same as pessimistic explanatory style.
Unrealistic and flexible optimism	Unrealistic optimism sees personal risk as below average (illness, failure) and can leave people unprepared. Flexible optimism or positive realism weighs good and bad outcomes realistically.	Saying more optimism is always better.

Construct	Key points	Common errors
Self-efficacy	Belief that one can perform the actions needed for a specific outcome ("the power of I can", Bandura). Domain- and situation-specific, not a trait; not the same as skill, self-esteem or outcome expectancy. Sources: mastery experiences (strongest), vicarious experience, verbal persuasion, imaginal experience. High self-efficacy links to persistence, resilience, health behaviour change and less depression.	Confusing self-efficacy with self-esteem; calling it a general trait.
Social cognitive theory	People are proactive and self-regulating; personal factors, behaviour and environment influence one another (triadic reciprocality). Bobo doll studies: children learn by observing others. Collective efficacy: a group's shared belief in its joint ability; linked to team success and school achievement.	Describing SCT as behaviourism.
Self-esteem	Seeing oneself as competent to cope and worthy of happiness. Types: global/specific, trait/state, contingent/true, explicit/implicit. Sociometer model: tracks social inclusion. Terror management model: shields against death anxiety (critiqued by Deci & Ryan). High but unstable self-esteem leads to anger. Self-esteem is often a result, not a cause, of good performance; affirmations can inflate it.	Saying raising self-esteem will raise performance.

Construct	Key points	Common errors
Hope theory	Hope = agency (I can start and keep going) + pathways (I can find routes to the goal) (Snyder). Matters most when goals are important and uncertain. High-hope people set harder goals, break them into subgoals and achieve more. Linked to self-esteem, coping, health and academic success.	Using the everyday meaning of "hope" (wishing).
Interventions	Best Possible Selves: write about your best possible future for 20 minutes on three days, then plan subgoals and pathways (Sheldon & Lyubomirsky). Sentence completion for self-esteem: quick endings to prompts each morning for a week (Branden).	Describing the exercises without the goal-planning step.

Connections across chapters

These items test level 5: comparing and linking ideas. A strong answer names both concepts, states the link, and gives evidence or an example.

Link	Expected answer	Common errors
SWB (Ch 3) vs PWB (Ch 4)	They are correlated but distinct (Keyes et al., 2002). A person can be satisfied and feel good (SWB) while lacking purpose, growth or autonomy (PWB). Example: Tariq, life satisfaction 7/10 but low purpose and growth.	Saying high SWB means high PWB.

Link	Expected answer	Common errors
Hedonic adaptation (Ch 3) and meaning (Ch 4)	Pleasure from purchases and events fades as we adapt (treadmill, lottery study). Eudaimonic pursuits give longer-lasting value (Seligman), and the HAP model's variety and intrinsic motivation fit eudaimonic activity.	Saying meaning also fades in the same way, with no evidence.
Learned helplessness (Ch 3 and Ch 5)	In Ch 3 it is one of the destructive interpretation patterns in the AIM approach. In Ch 5 it is the model explanatory style grew from: believing actions do not matter leads to giving up. Example: Dana stops attending after one failure.	Treating it as two unrelated ideas.
Optimism (Ch 5) and SWB (Ch 3)	Optimism is linked to positive affect, active coping and better health (bypass study); positive emotions predict resistance to colds and longer life. Both chapters also warn that too much optimism can delay medical help.	Missing the shared warning about unrealistic optimism.
Autonomy (Ch 4) and locus of control (Ch 5)	Autonomy is acting from one's own volition (SDT). Internal LOC is believing outcomes depend on one's own actions. Related but different: someone can feel in control of results yet not choose their goals (Tariq), or choose freely yet credit luck. The nursing home study touches both: choice and control.	Treating them as the same concept.

Link	Expected answer	Common errors
Goals across chapters	Ch 3: progress toward valued, self-congruent goals produces happiness. Ch 4: purpose in life (Ryff) and meaning. Ch 5: hope = agency + pathways toward goals; self-efficacy and optimism keep people moving toward them.	Listing goals in one chapter only.

Mock essay questions: outlines of strong answers

A strong essay defines terms, uses named studies as evidence, presents both sides, and ends with a clear judgement. Each outline lists what a top answer should cover.

Chapter 3

1. **Evaluate the evidence on the correlates and predictors of SWB.**
   - Define SWB (Diener) and how it is measured.
   - Correlates: income (strong in poor nations, small above a moderate level; Forbes study), relationships (ESM, contagion), marriage (temporary boost), children (curvilinear), work orientation, health (colds, longevity), religion (small, culture-dependent); age and gender show little effect.
   - Evaluate: mostly correlational and cross-sectional, so cause is unclear; self-report bias; cultural differences; bottom-up vs top-down debate.
   - Judgement: relationships and health are more reliable predictors than income or circumstances.
2. **Merits and shortcomings of SWB as a way to conceptualise and measure happiness.**
   - Merits: clear definition, short reliable scales, global comparison (Gallup, World Values Survey), predicts health and behaviour.
   - Shortcomings: hedonic only, ignores meaning and growth (bridge to Ch 4, Ryff); mood effects and memory bias; cultural meaning of "happiness"; single-occasion measures.
   - Improvements: ESM, diaries, physiological measures, longitudinal designs.
3. **Do we always return to our set point after events?**
   - Yes side: dynamic equilibrium (Headey & Wearing), hedonic treadmill, lottery winners and paraplegics (Brickman), marriage returning to baseline after about a year, impact bias (Gilbert).

- No side: lasting effects of spouse's death (5–7 years) and long-term unemployment; set point now challenged (Headey, 2008); 40% intentional activity; HAP model shows variety and surprise slow adaptation.
- Judgement: adaptation is strong but not complete or universal.

Chapter 4

4. **Compare and contrast subjective and psychological wellbeing.**
   - SWB: hedonic, life satisfaction + affect (Diener). PWB: eudaimonic, Ryff's six dimensions.
   - Similarities: both are self-reported, both are linked to health, and they correlate (self-acceptance and mastery overlap most).
   - Differences: feeling good vs functioning well; different links to demographics and personality (Keyes et al., 2002).
   - Critiques of both: SWB ignores meaning; PWB's six factors may reduce to two (Vittersø).
   - Example: a case like Tariq shows high SWB with low PWB.
5. **Can we arrive at a common definition of eudaimonic wellbeing?**
   - Many frameworks: Ryff's PWB, Seligman's engaged and meaningful life, flow, SDT, meaning (Frankl, Steger), existential happiness (Wong).
   - Points of disagreement: state, process or trait; is it growth, meaning or transcendence; how it relates to hedonic wellbeing (independent, overlapping, identical).
   - Shared core: realising potential, acting in line with values, meaning beyond pleasure.
   - Judgement: a shared core exists, but no single definition yet (Boniwell calls the area "a mess"); more bottom-up and qualitative research is needed.
6. **"I would rather wake up unhappy than without meaning in my life." Discuss.**
   - For: Frankl's will to meaning; meaning protects against suicidal behaviour; existential view that discontent drives growth and contentment can be a void (Wong); meaningful life gives long-term value (Seligman).
   - Against: hedonic wellbeing predicts health and longevity (Ch 3); meaning and happiness often go together (King & Napa); a search for meaning can lower wellbeing for a time.
   - Judgement: the choice is a false dichotomy for most people; the best outcome combines both, but meaning may matter more in the long run.

Chapter 5

7. **Strengths and limitations of Snyder's hope theory.**

- Theory: agency + pathways; most relevant for important, uncertain goals.
- Strengths: clear cognitive model; measurable; links to coping, health and academic achievement; practical (subgoals, used in CBT); can be changed, unlike trait optimism.
- Limitations: overlaps with self-efficacy, optimism and other constructs; mostly correlational evidence; very cognitive, so it may miss emotion; differs from the everyday meaning of hope; cultural fit not established.

8. **Is seeing the glass as half full always beneficial?**
   - Benefits: coping, lower depression, health and recovery (bypass study), sales (88%), positive illusions helping in illness (Taylor).
   - Costs: unrealistic optimism underestimates risk; optimists can be unprepared for trauma; happy people may delay medical help (Ch 3).
   - Pessimism can help: defensive pessimism (Norem) improves performance for anxious people; making them think positively backfires.
   - Judgement: flexible, realistic optimism is best; it depends on the person and the situation.
9. **Compare and contrast dispositional optimism and explanatory style.**
   - Dispositional (Scheier & Carver): trait, general expectancy about the future, self-regulation of goals, LOT-R.
   - Explanatory style (Seligman): learned, explains why past events happened, internal/stable/global, ASQ, rooted in learned helplessness, changeable with ABC.
   - Similarities: both predict coping, health and achievement; measures correlate (Peterson).
   - Differences: trait vs skill; future vs past; what vs why; different interventions.
   - Link to hope: explanatory style and hope can change more than dispositional optimism.